

Black bean tofu tacos

Black bean tacos are a special favorite of mine. It's the cooking techniques and special care you put into preparing this dish that make it simply **exquisite**—roasting the chiles, roasting and peeling the tomatoes, cooking the thinly sliced onion until it is soft and sweet. There are a few steps, yes, but they are not complicated. The recipe calls for a cast-iron skillet; I find it's the best tool for roasting garlic and chiles on the stovetop.

1¼ pound ripe tomatoes, cored and cut horizontally in half [625g]

4 garlic cloves, unpeeled

2 small serrano peppers or 1 jalapeño pepper, stems removed

1 large white onion, thinly sliced

2 tablespoons olive oil

2½ teaspoons oregano, preferably Mexican

1¼ teaspoon cumin seeds, lightly crushed

2 teaspoons unrefined cane sugar

1 teaspoon salt

2 to 2½ cups cooked black beans [330 to 400g]

½ to ¾ pound firm tofu, pressed dry, cut into ½" cubes [300g]*

1½ ripe avocados

8 corn tortillas, steamed until hot and tender

Your favorite salsa (or one of mine), for topping

1. **Preheat** the broiler with the rack set 5 to 6 inches [13 to 15cm] from the heat. Set out the tomatoes, skin side up, on a baking pan. Broil until the tomatoes are slightly charred and the skins are wrinkled and peeling off, 3 to 5 minutes. When cool, pull off the skins. Coarsely chop the tomatoes, saving the juice.
2. In a medium-size cast-iron skillet set over medium heat, **dry-roast** the garlic and hot peppers, turning until the garlic skins are browned in spots, 5 to 7 minutes, and the peppers are blistered and soft, 10 to 15 minutes. When cool, peel the garlic and smash into a paste or coarsely chop. Stem and seed the peppers and coarsely chop them.

*Tofu is usually sold in 16-ounce [500-g] packages. For this recipe, you will need less than that amount. If you are not doubling the recipe, cover the remaining tofu in cold water and refrigerate.

3. In the same pan over medium-high heat, **sauté** the onion in the olive oil until very soft and lightly browned, 7 to 9 minutes.
4. Add the toasted garlic and peppers and the oregano, cumin seeds, sugar, and salt to the onion. **Cook**, stirring, for 1 minute. Add the cooked beans and the chopped tomatoes with their juices. Cook, stirring often, until the mixture begins to thicken slightly. If you like, mash some of the beans in the pan.
5. **Fold** in the tofu cubes and reduce the heat to medium-low. Simmer the bean filling for a few minutes before serving.
6. Peel and mash the avocado. To make tacos, spread a tablespoon or so of avocado over each warm tortilla. **Top** with the black bean filling and salsa to taste. Roll up and eat.

MAKES 8 TACOS; SERVES 4

note If you have a lower-quality pan that is thin and tends to burn easily, I recommend spreading out aluminum foil in the pan to roast the garlic and chiles. It will help diffuse the heat.

